

PRODUCTION JOURNAL : *THE SEA THAT DREAMED*

by Roxanne Ducharme

What the film means to me

On the surface, *THE SEA THAT DREAMED* is about a creature, a jar of eyes, and a sea that turns into a garden. Underneath, it is about those moments in life when you feel like you have no past, no clear future, and yet you keep moving because you have seen just enough beauty to not give up.

Wynn does not remember who he “really” is and he never finds a way back to the surface. Instead, he transforms the only world he has with the dreams he has collected along the way. That, to me, is the core of the film: we do not always escape our circumstances, but we can carry visions, memories and dreams, and sometimes that is enough to quietly change the water around us.

Writing the story and narration

The story and narration came first, before anything else.

This film began with a feeling rather than a plot. I was overwhelmed by the news from Ukraine and Gaza, thinking of people living through war and suffering. I wanted to make something quietly hopeful, a visual poem in a chaotic world and a small reminder not to give up, to keep dreaming.

Visually, I imagined an underwater world that felt familiar but slightly wrong, almost dreamlike. Not a “pretty aquarium,” but a forgotten corner of the ocean where time does not move properly.

I used ChatGPT to develop the narrative structure and co-write the voice-over script. This allowed for a fluid, intuitive writing process that shaped the emotional tone of the film early on.

I knew the voiceover had to sound like a bedtime story told from far away: simple but not childish, like reading from a worn-out storybook found in an attic.

Once the text was locked, I generated multiple takes of the narration and edited together the best moments from each. The final voiceover is a composite of several recordings, chosen for tone, clarity, and emotional nuance rather than relying on a single pass.

Music

From the beginning, I knew I wanted something very simple and melancholic, carried mainly by a cello. No big themes, no dramatic crescendos, just a gentle, emotional undercurrent that could sit behind the narration and the sound design without overwhelming them.

The goal was for the viewer to feel it more than notice it, like an invisible thread holding all the images and memories together.

The creature with no sky

I knew I wanted an underwater creature that looked strange but not frightening, cute, but not in a cartoonish way.

An axolotl felt like the right choice. Axolotls can regenerate parts of their body, including limbs, gills, and even parts of their eyes and brain. That ability quietly mirrors the idea of resilience: healing, adapting, and continuing in spite of damage. Because axolotls are also critically endangered, the axolotl also echoes the vulnerability of people and communities trying to survive war, climate change, displacement, and loss.

He also needed a name, if only so I could talk about him to myself while I worked. I chose “Wynn” from a list of names suggested by ChatGPT: short, soft, slightly strange. It fit him immediately.

The jar of eyes

The “jar of eyeballs” sounds grotesque, but in my mind it was never meant as horror. It was always a container of borrowed vision.

The idea came quickly: these eyes have seen a world Wynn has never known, the world above. Sky, rain, flowers, laughter, color. All the things that do not exist in his underwater life.

Visually, I wanted the jar to feel like an intruder in the deep, something that clearly does not belong there. From a storytelling point of view, it is both a memory device and a projector of dreams. It is how Wynn begins to “remember” experiences that were never his, and how he starts to imagine something beyond the darkness around him.

Building the sea

For the environment, I wanted a sense of emptiness at the beginning: an underwater landscape devoid of vegetation, mostly bare rock formations, monochromatic. Different arrangements of

rock appear in the backgrounds, but they blur together and emphasize that everything looks the same. Just enough texture to feel alive, but not enough to feel comforting.

When color arrives

The whole film hinges on one arc: from absence to presence, from monochromatic blue to color.

At first, color exists only inside the visions, flowers, fields, sky, brief moments from above the water. Wynn's world stays mostly monochrome.

The final sequence, when the jar is placed on the coral tower, is where everything transforms. I wanted it to feel like memory leaking into reality, like liquid color seeping through the sea.

Color bleeds, then blooms. Plants and corals become strangely floral, as if surface memories are being reinterpreted by the ocean. It is not realistic biology; it is emotional logic. The deep becomes a garden.

Directing AI

Technically, this film was built through a lot of iteration and rejection. I was not interested in showing off what the AI tools could do. I wanted them to disappear behind Wynn's story.

Much of the work was about controlling the camera: finding that drifting, wandering movement that feels like being carried by a current without making the viewer seasick. Small arcs, slow dolly moves, gentle parallax. Always a little in motion, never entirely stable, like the sea itself.

Sound effects and the feeling of water

The soundscape had to do a lot of invisible work. Underwater is naturally muffled, but I did not want the film to feel dead.

So the sound lives in subtle layers:

- low, distant rumbles for the deep,
- small, intimate movements for Wynn,
- and delicate, shimmering accents when the visions and colors appear, like little bursts of underwater magic rather than realistic ambience.

Experiments, obstacles, and results

One of the main obstacles was keeping Wynn consistent from shot to shot. Generating different angles of the creature while preserving the same number of external gills, fingers, toes, and a stable tail shape was surprisingly difficult. Both the image generators and the AI video tools kept subtly changing his proportions: the tail would grow or shrink, limbs would deform, even the body shape shifted between clips. I had to regenerate and refine many versions of the same actions and viewpoints until I reached a set of shots where Wynn felt like the same creature throughout the film.

I also experimented with a “paint in water” effect for the color transformation. I generated abstract color motion using text-to-video, then layered these clips on top of the flower and coral animation in the edit. By trying different blending modes and opacities, I turned the color into a moving veil that interacts with the shapes underneath, so it feels like waves of pigment washing over the scene rather than a simple overlay.